

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

S

Salvation in Isaiah

The prophet Isaiah's name means Yahweh is salvation. He urges people to turn from false saviors to God who is the only true savior and protector. Salvation affects all parts of life, including physical and spiritual aspects. For example, the word salvation sometimes appears in the book of Isaiah with righteousness to show a peaceful order where injustice, disgrace, and mourning do not exist (Isaiah 45:8; 51:8).

Isaiah often shares the gospel (the good news about Jesus) that the Lord will come to help his people (for example, 4:2-6; 10:24-34; 40:9-11). Although God promised punishment and exile because of the wrongdoing of the Israelites, the Lord would not abandon them. Instead, he would save them. Babylon's power and the suffering and shame of the exile would end. Chapters 1-39 prophesy this message, while chapters 40-66 explain it plainly.

Isaiah talks about the salvation God would bring through Jesus Christ. He prophesies "a Branch" from King David's family line who would have the Holy Spirit and bring justice and righteousness (11:1-5). He also mentions God's servant who would suffer for the people's sins (52:13-53:12). Jesus fulfilled Isaiah's prophecies and saved humanity from sin and death.

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 27:1; Isaiah 49:8; Isaiah 59:15-21; Isaiah 61:1-3; Luke 4:18-21; John 3:16-17; John 12:47; Romans 10:9-13; 2 Corinthians 5:18-21; Titus 2:11-13; Hebrews 9:27-28; 1 Peter 3:18-21; Revelation 7:9-10

Salvation in the Psalms

The writers of the psalms (called psalmists) considered God's salvation as a rescue from evil in the world. They had suffered a lot. During difficult times, they felt God had abandoned them. Meanwhile, evil people used this supposed injustice to mock godly people (Psalm 3:2; 71:10-11).

The psalmists called out for help, knowing they relied entirely on the Lord (31:15; 35:17; 69:13). While waiting for help, they trusted that the Lord was present, watching over them (Psalms 46, 121). He would not abandon them (16:10; 94:14; see also 7:10; 31:2; 62:6-7; 144:2).

God graciously rescues his needy servants and answers their prayers (20:6; 28:8; 34:6, 18; 40:1-2; 76:9; 107; 145:19; 149:4). When the Lord rescues his people, he

gains glory when they thank, praise, and witness of him (50:15; 79:9; 85:9). The Bible records God's mighty acts. This is so that his people will praise him for what he has done and trust him to rescue them.

The psalms encourage Christians to relate to these stories of salvation. For example, in Psalm 18, the psalmist talks about his distress, his cries, and the Lord's rescue (18:17, 19, 20, 43, 48). This invites all humble people to hope in the Lord (see 72:12). The Lord has saved his people throughout history and will do so again.

Salvation does not include evil people (69:27; 119:155). Evil people mock those who trust in the Lord's rescue (22:8). Evil people might cry for help to the Lord during judgment, but he will not save them (18:27; 50:22). Hoping for God's salvation requires living by trust and love for the Lord (119:123; 60:5; 108:6). This kind of faith removes fear, knowing that the Lord acts righteously (34:4; 71:2).

The Lord Jesus came to save sinners. He helped those in need and on the edges of society. He provided physical relief to many. He died under oppression to bring spiritual freedom to the world. He saves people from themselves, from Satan, from death, and from difficulty.

He has the power to support the faithful, judge sinners, and fully save all of God's children. He will renew everything while excluding evil people from his eternal salvation.

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 3:7-8; 6:4; 7:10; 14:7; 16:9-11; 17:7; 18:1-50; 20:6; 22:4-5; 25:4-14; 27:1; 31:1-2, 15-16; 32:1-5; 33:18-19; 34:6-7, 17-19; 40:16-17; 43:5; 46:1-11; 62:1-8; 70:4-5; 72:12-14; 80:1-19; 91:1-16; 98:1-3; 107:1-43; 121:1-8; 149:4

The Secret of the Messiah

In the Gospel of Mark, Jesus often tells people not to reveal his true identity as the Messiah (God's chosen one). This includes:

- those Jesus healed or raised from the dead,
- the disciples who knew Jesus was the Christ (the Greek word for Messiah), and
- the demons who understood Jesus' true identity (see Mark 1:34, 44; 3:11-12; 5:43; 7:36; 8:29-30; 9:9).

This theme (often called the "Messianic Secret") appears less often in the Gospels of Matthew and Luke (see Matthew 8:4; 16:20; Luke 9:21). Why did Jesus command those he healed and those who knew his true identity to keep both his healing miracles and his identity a secret?

One possibility relates to how the Roman authorities would have reacted. During his earthly ministry, Jesus was a very popular preacher who announced the arrival of God's kingdom. He miraculously healed people and allowed his followers to call him Israel's long-awaited Messiah and King.

Roman authorities would not allow this. They would quickly try to stop such a movement. In the Roman Empire, there was no room for another kingdom or messianic rescuer within Roman rule. Therefore, even though Jesus told his disciples he was the Christ, he did not plan to lead a political revolution against Rome (Mark 8:27-30).

Another reason Jesus might have wanted to keep his true identity secret might be the widely misunderstood identity of Jesus in the Gospel of Mark. There was a misunderstanding even among his closest followers. Jesus makes it clear that his role as Messiah, the Son of God, is directly related to his suffering and death. This reality did not match Jewish expectations of the Messiah.

Right after the apostle Peter declares Jesus as the Christ (the Messiah), Jesus announces he will suffer and die (Mark 8:27-31). Peter's response shows he does not understand (8:32-33). Jesus' miracles and deep teaching were important, but his death as a sacrifice was the most important part of his role as the Messiah.

For these reasons, Jesus found it wise to teach about God's kingdom using parables. Parables are stories that have symbolic meanings (see Mark 4:1-34, especially 4:10-12). This approach helped reduce the excitement caused by his miracles (1:44; 5:43; 7:36; 8:26). It also allowed him to hide his presence at times from the people (7:24; 9:30-31). He kept his teachings hidden from outsiders (4:10-12, 33-34; 7:17). He instructed those who knew his true identity not to reveal it (Mark 1:23-26, 34; 3:11-12; 8:29-30; 9:9). Jesus came "to give his life as a ransom for many" (10:45). He did not come to lead the nation of Israel in a rebellion against Rome.

But Jesus Christ, the Son of God, could not be hidden (Mark 1:1). The secret was impossible to keep because Jesus is too important (7:36). Those who experienced his healing and saw him heal others could not stop sharing what he did. Jesus's identity became clear, and people realized he is truly the Messiah, the Son of God, the one with power over nature, sickness, and death. For readers and hearers of the Gospel of Mark who learn of his identity in the first verse, Jesus proved

to be the Messiah because of (not in spite of) his suffering, death, and resurrection.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 8:4; 16:20; Mark 1:34, 44; 3:11-12; 5:43; 7:36; 8:29-30; 9:9, 30-31; Luke 9:21

Security and Obedience

The Book of Life is a divine record that contains the names of those who belong to God and will receive eternal life (Revelation 20:12). The idea of removing a name from the Book of Life may raise questions about whether salvation can be lost (Revelation 3:5). Does not the New Testament tell believers that their salvation is secure?

The New Testament offers many words of comfort (for example, John 10:27-30; 1 Corinthians 10:13; Hebrews 6:18-20). But it also gives strong warnings (for example, John 15:6; 1 Corinthians 10:6-12; Hebrews 6:4-8; Revelation 2:4-5; 3:11). We often dislike and avoid these warnings because they make us feel less secure. Yet, this concern for security is exactly why the New Testament writers gave these warnings. They emphasized the need for obedience, faithfulness, and endurance.

This call to obedience was not new. God repeatedly called the people of Israel to be faithful (for example, Genesis 12:1-2; 15:1-18; 22:16-18; 28:13-14; 1 Samuel 12:19-25; 15:10-11; 28:16-19; 2 Samuel 7:11-16; 1 Kings 9:4-9). All of God's promises and prophecies depend on faithfulness and obedience (see especially Jeremiah 18:7-10). The apostle Paul understood that Israel's disobedience led to some being "broken off" from God's people (Romans 11:17). He warned non-Jewish (gentile) Christians not to be overconfident of their position (Romans 11:13-32). God's promise remains the same, but human disobedience leads to judgment. True security comes from humble obedience and reliance on God.

During New Testament times, being a Christian was difficult and dangerous. The book of Revelation offers hope for Christians, even when threatened by death. This hope comes with warnings about judgment (Revelation 21:8, 27; 22:15). The call to faithfulness and obedience are major themes in Revelation (see 2:5, 10-11, 16-17, 26-29; 3:2, 12, 17-19, 21-22; 7:14; 13:9-10, 12; 16:15; 18:4; 20:12; 21:7; 22:3, 7, 11-12). The New Testament affirms that with God's help, faithful Christians will persevere to the end (see Hebrews 13:6; James 1:25; Revelation 3:10).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 15:1, 13–16; 1 Samuel 12:22–25; 1 Kings 9:4–9; Jeremiah 18:7–10; John 10:27–30; 15:6; Romans 11:13–32; 1 Corinthians 10:6–12; Hebrews 6:4–8, 18–20; 13:6; James 1:25; Revelation 2:5, 10–11, 16–17; 3:5, 10–12; 18:4; 20:12; 21:7–8; 22:11–12

Seeking the Lord

As Israel was about to enter the promised land, Moses instructed the people to “seek the place the LORD your God will choose from among all your tribes” (Deuteronomy 12:5). Moses told the Israelites to stop pagan worship practices and focus on worshipping God. In the wilderness, they built the tabernacle where God would show his presence and where the people would worship him. Once settled in the promised land, Moses told them to build a permanent holy place.

During the time of the judges, the people of Israel often worshipped the gods of nearby nations instead of the one true God. When the kingdom began, there was hope that the whole nation would unite in worshipping God. Yet, the first king, Saul, lost the kingdom and his life partly because “he consulted a medium for guidance” instead of the Lord (1 Chronicles 10:13–14). Many kings in Israel’s history followed Saul’s example of disobedience and led the nation into pagan religious practices.

King David, in contrast, was “a man after His own heart” (1 Samuel 13:14). As king, one of David’s main goals was to restore the importance of the ark of the covenant. The Israelites had ignored it during Saul’s time (1 Chronicles 13:3).

David failed in his first attempt to bring the ark to Jerusalem. This was because he and the Levites did not ask for the Lord’s guidance on how to transport it (13:1–14; 15:13). David later succeeded in bringing the ark to Jerusalem (15:1–16:1).

The holy place and worship in Jerusalem were essential for seeking the Lord. After placing the ark in its tent in Jerusalem, David created a new role for the Levites as music ministers (1 Chronicles 16:4–6). David often urged leaders to “seek the Lord your God” while building the temple (22:19; compare 28:8–10).

King Solomon’s first action to strengthen the kingdom was to gather all the leaders at the altar in Gibeon to seek the Lord (2 Chronicles 1:1–6). The Lord met Solomon there and gave him unmatched wisdom and wealth. Later, Solomon finished the temple and established it as a place to seek the Lord (2 Chronicles 6).

Isaiah the prophet encouraged people waiting for God’s promises to seek him. “Seek the LORD while He

may be found; call on Him while He is near” (Isaiah 55:6). God’s covenant and promise are certain, and they are for those who seek the Lord (55:3).

Passages for Further Study

1 Chronicles 10:13–14; 13:3; 16:11–13; 22:19; 28:8–10; 2 Chronicles 6:19–40; 7:14; Psalms 27:4–8; 105:4–6; Isaiah 55:6–7; Jeremiah 29:13–14; Matthew 6:31–33; Romans 2:7

The Servant-Leader

A servant-leader is a person who has a strong desire to achieve a goal by helping and serving others. This type of leader desires to take on the role of a servant rather than focusing on their own authority or status.

The Old Testament describes Moses as the Lord’s servant (Exodus 14:31; Numbers 12:7–8). Moses did not seek power, fame, or material gain. He hesitated to assume his leadership role. He used his prophetic authority with humility (Numbers 12:3). He knew he was under God’s authority (see Deuteronomy 34:10–12; Hosea 12:13).

From the time God called him, every event in Moses’ story shows that he regarded his leadership as service to God. He submitted to God, did not care for himself, and was faithful. The way he acted toward the Israelites showed concern, a desire to persuade, and vision. Moses took a leadership role at a critical moment in Israelite history and often prayed or interceded for the people. He humbly submitted to God, which was the foundation of his great leadership.

Jesus of Nazareth is the perfect servant-leader. The gospels show Jesus as the Lord’s “suffering servant” (see Isaiah 52:13–53:12). This was especially shown through his sacrificial death, the ultimate act of service (Mark 10:45). Jesus spoke with great authority but with humility. He knew his role was like a shepherd who “lays down His life for the sheep” (John 10:11).

He spent time with children and used them as examples for those who want to fully follow God (Matthew 18:4). When James and John asked for important positions in his kingdom, Jesus criticized their worldly ambition (Mark 10:35–45). He corrected them by teaching them to follow his example as a servant (Matthew 20:24–28; 23:11–12; Mark 10:43–45). As a model for all who want to lead others through a life of service, Jesus knew his purpose was to bring glory to God’s name (John 12:27–28).

The apostles Paul and Peter followed Christ’s example and lived according to his ideal of servant leadership. Paul’s life of service showed humility and self-sacri-

fice for others (see 2 Corinthians 11:23–28). He taught Christians to do the same (Romans 8:17; Galatians 5:13; 2 Timothy 1:8; 2:3). He praised those who did (for example, Philippians 2:25–30; Colossians 4:7).

Peter also showed self-sacrificial service for Christ (for example, Acts 3:1–11; 4:13–22; 5:12–16; 9:32–42). His instructions plainly define the character of a servant-leader (1 Peter 4:10–11; 5:1–5).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 13:8–12; 14:11–24; 30:31–32; Exodus 14:31; Numbers 12:3, 7–8; Deuteronomy 34:10–12; 1 Kings 12:1–7; Isaiah 52:13–53:12; Matthew 18:4; 20:24–28; 23:11–12; Mark 10:35–45; John 10:11; 12:27–28; Acts 3:1–11; 4:13–22; 5:12–16; 9:32–42; Romans 8:17; 2 Corinthians 11:23–27; Galatians 5:13; Philippians 2:25–30; Colossians 4:7; 2 Timothy 1:8; 2:3; 1 Peter 4:10–11; 5:1–5

The Seventy Sets of Seven

The “seventy weeks” (or sevens) in Daniel 9:24–27 have always been difficult to understand. Although it is difficult to connect them to a specific historical period, these “seventy sets of seven” are important. They show God’s control over history and emphasize his power to fulfill his plans for his people. The number seventy is seven times ten. This symbolizes completeness. For instance, the seventy years of exile for God’s people were enough time to discipline them (9:2).

Here are the two main ways people understand the seventy sets of seven:

1. **THE RULE OF ANTIOCHUS IV (175–163 BC).** According to this view, the seventy sets of seven is a time period that begins with Cyrus II of Persia and ends with Antiochus IV. Cyrus II (also known as Cyrus the Great) was the king of Persia who ruled from 559 to around 530 BC. In 539 BC, Cyrus allowed the Jewish people to return to their homeland (see 9:25; Ezra 1:2–4). Antiochus IV was a Greek king who ruled over Syria and the surrounding areas from 175 to 163 BC (see Daniel 8:23–25; 11:21–39).

In this understanding of the seventy sets of seven, “the Messiah” (or chosen one) was the high priest Onias III, and the “prince” was Antiochus IV (9:26–27). Antiochus made a treaty with the people of Judea in 174 BC, allowing them to practice their faith peacefully. But in 170 BC, Antiochus attacked Jerusalem, killed many, and stole from the temple.

Then, in 167 BC, Antiochus ended the sacrifices and offerings. He forced the Jews to abandon their faith under threat of death. He made the temple ceremonially unclean with “the abomination of desolation” (some-

thing that showed disrespect for God and his holy temple). Antiochus placed a statue of the Greek god Zeus on the altar of burnt offering. He also sacrificed pigs on the altar and other ceremonially unclean animals (compare 11:21–35).

God punished Antiochus with a painful disease, and Antiochus died in 163 BC. “The decreed destruction” was “poured out on him” (9:27; see also 8:25; 1 Maccabees 1:10–24; 6:7–16; 2 Maccabees 9:1–29).

According to this view, when Jesus spoke of the “the abomination of desolation,” he referred to the Jews’ experience during Antiochus’s time as a model for future events (see Matthew 24:15; compare Luke 21:20; 2 Thessalonians 2:3–4).

1. **THE DEATH OF JESUS CHRIST (AD 30 or 33).** According to this view, the seventy weeks are a prophecy about Jesus Christ, the Messiah (God’s chosen one). People who support this view think the seventy sets of seven began with Cyrus’s decree in 539 BC (Ezra 1:1–4). Or, it may have begun with one of the decrees given to Nehemiah in either 458 or 445 BC (Ezra 7:8–26; Nehemiah 2:1–10). Jesus may have died at the end of sixty-nine sets of seven (seven plus sixty-two, Daniel 9:25–26). Or, it may have been halfway through the seventieth year (9:27).

These two options affect how the seventy sets of seven conclude. In the first option, the seventieth set of seven is a future event not yet fulfilled. In the second option, the seventieth set of seven finished when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70. If Cyrus’s decree is the starting point, the 490 years are symbolic. Yet, if the decree given to Nehemiah in 445 BC to rebuild the city is the starting point, then nearly 483 years (69 times 7 years) passed between that date and Jesus’ death in AD 30 or 33 (see Nehemiah 2:1; Daniel 9:25).

Scholars have two different ways of explaining what happened to the seventieth set of seven years:

1. The Seventieth Set of Seven is Yet to Occur. Many interpreters believe that Jesus’ death happened at the end of the sixty-ninth set of seven. They think the seventieth set of sevens has not yet happened. This means there is a long gap between the sixty-ninth and seventieth sets. The seventieth set is still in the future and links to the antichrist’s rule during the final troubles (the tribulation) at the end of history (see 2 Thessalonians 2:3–12; 1 John 2:18–22; 4:3; 2 John 1:7; Revelation 13:1, 5; 16:13–14; 17:11; 19:20–21; 20:10).
2. The Seventieth Set of Seven Completed When Rome Destroyed Jerusalem and the Temple. Some interpreters believe the seventy weeks ended with the coming of Jesus, his death and resurrection, and

the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70.

In this view, Jesus started his ministry at the end of the sixty-ninth set of seven, around AD 28. He ministered for about three and a half years and died in the middle of the seventieth seven. The remaining half-seven concluded when the “prince” (one or more Roman leaders) destroyed Jerusalem and its temple in AD 70. The conflict and suffering between God’s people and the world’s kingdom continue until the end. This is when Jesus will return, judge the wicked, and establish his kingdom.

Passages for Further Study

Daniel 7:8, 11, 20–21, 24–27; 8:9–14; 9:24–27; 11:29–31, 40–45; 12:7, 11; 2 Thessalonians 2:3–12; 1 John 2:18–22; 4:3; 2 John 1:7; Revelation 13:1, 5; 16:13–14; 17:11; 19:20–21; 20:10

Shechem

Shechem was in an important location at the entrance to the passage between Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim. It could control several important roads through the central hill country. Jacob bought land near Shechem (Genesis 33:18–19).

While there, the local prince named Shechem raped Jacob’s daughter, Dinah. In response, Dinah’s brothers, Simeon and Levi, killed all the men in the area (Genesis 34). Later, Shechem became part of Joseph’s inheritance (Joshua 24:32). It was also one of the special cities where people could go to find protection if they accidentally killed someone (see Deuteronomy 19:1–13; Joshua 20:7).

During the time of the judges, Gideon’s son Abimelech ruled from Shechem (Judges 9). King Solomon later strengthened Shechem as a provincial capital. But Shishak of Egypt probably destroyed it when he invaded Israel in 926 BC (see 1 Kings 14:25). Jeroboam I then rebuilt the city and made it the capital of the kingdom of Israel (1 Kings 12:25). The Assyrian king Shalmaneser V destroyed Shechem again in 724 BC. This was shortly before Samaria’s destruction. The ruins remained mostly uninhabited for about four hundred years.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 33:18–19; Joshua 8:30–35; 20:7; 24:1–32; Judges 9:1–56; 1 Kings 12:1, 25; John 4:5

The Shepherd

In ancient Jewish society, shepherds who cared for sheep or goats were important. Shepherding was es-

sential in the ancient Near East. Each morning, the shepherd led the flock out (John 10:2–4). He found grass and water and protected them from wild animals (Amos 3:12). He searched for and returned any of the flock that wandered off (Ezekiel 34:8; Matthew 18:12). He returned the flock to the pen every evening.

The word shepherd became a common term for a ruler. People often referred to the kings of Assyria, Babylon, and Egypt as shepherds because they protected their people. This metaphor is also common in the Old Testament (Numbers 27:17; 1 Kings 22:17; Jeremiah 10:21; 23:1–2; Ezekiel 34:1–10).

The Old Testament regards God as the “Shepherd of Israel,” caring for every part of his people’s well-being (Genesis 49:24; Psalms 23:1; 80:1; Isaiah 40:11). God himself would take care of his flock (Jeremiah 23:3; 31:10; Ezekiel 34:11–22). He promised to provide faithful leaders who cared for his people (Jeremiah 3:15; 23:4).

When Israel’s early leaders were unfaithful, God took action and chose his servant David as a faithful leader. He later promised to establish David’s descendants as leaders over Israel (see Ezekiel 34:23–24). By the time of the prophet Jeremiah, shepherd began to refer to the coming Messiah (God’s chosen one).

In the New Testament, Jesus called himself “the Shepherd” (Matthew 25:31–33; Mark 14:27; John 10:1–30). He is the “Good Shepherd” who sacrifices his life for the sheep (John 10:11–18; see also Hebrews 13:20).

The church leaders are also known as shepherds (Ephesians 4:11, translated as “pastors”). God gives them to the church to care for his people like a shepherd cares for sheep, guiding and teaching them in God’s ways. They must remain faithful shepherds until Jesus Christ, “the Chief Shepherd,” comes to lead his people directly (1 Peter 5:1–4).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 29:1–10; Numbers 27:16–18; 2 Samuel 7:7; 1 Kings 22:17; 1 Chronicles 11:2; Psalms 23:1–6; 77:20; 80:1; Isaiah 40:11; 44:28; 56:10–11; Jeremiah 10:21; 25:34–36; Ezekiel 34:1–31; Micah 7:14; Zechariah 10:2b–3; 11:4–17; 13:7; Matthew 2:6; 18:12–14; 26:31; John 10:1–16; 1 Peter 2:25; 5:1–4; Jude 1:12; Revelation 7:17

Sin Enters the World

Genesis 3 explains how humans lost their moral innocence by rebelling against God. What God called “very good” was no longer perfect (Genesis 1:31). The man and woman ate the fruit that promised knowledge of good and evil, disobeying God’s command (2:16–17). They tried to become like God (see 3:5). By doing this,

they gave up their sinless state. They became separated from God, each other, and creation. They also experienced death.

As a result, all humans are “fallen,” meaning they are born into a corrupt world that causes a tendency to sin (Genesis 8:21; Job 4:17–21; Psalms 51:5; 103:10; 143:2; Proverbs 20:9). All humans also now experience death. When the first man and woman disobeyed God by eating the fruit, they lost their innocence. Their descendants and the entire human race now inherit a cursed world (Romans 5:12–14; 1 Corinthians 15:21–22, 45–49).

The term “original sin” describes how the effects of the first sin of Adam and Eve have spread into individual lives and society because of human rebellion. As people submit to their tendency to sin, they become accountable for their own actions (Ecclesiastes 7:20; Romans 3:23).

The first man, Adam, brought sin into the world, but the “second Adam,” Jesus Christ, is the solution to sin (1 Corinthians 15:3; 2 Corinthians 5:21). When Christ died as redeemer, he offered God’s salvation from sin to everyone (John 3:16; Romans 1:16)

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 3:1–19; 8:21; Exodus 34:7; Job 4:17–21; Psalm 51:5; Proverbs 22:15; Ezekiel 36:16–36; John 8:1–11; Romans 1:18–3:20; 5:12–21; 1 Corinthians 15:21–22; Galatians 3:22; 5:17–24; Ephesians 2:1–10; 1 John 3:14

Slavery

Slavery was common in the Roman world. Prisoners of war often became slaves, many were born into slavery, and some chose slavery temporarily to pay off debts. A large part of the population, including many Christians, were slaves or former slaves (see Acts 6:9). So, why did the apostle Paul not speak against slavery?

There are two reasons. First, slavery in the Roman world was different from the slavery familiar to the modern western world. It was not based on race and was rarely lifelong. Most slaves expected freedom by age thirty. Some people even sold themselves into slavery to increase social status. Some slaves were well-educated and held important roles in their households and society. Many had friendly relationships with their masters. In the Roman world, Christians like Philemon did not feel guilty about owning slaves.

Second, Paul did not oppose slavery because it was not his mission to change society’s structures but to build the church. He wanted people to convert and transform spiritually. For Paul, whether a Christian is

a slave or not is not very important, just like other external circumstances. The key is serving Jesus Christ, no matter one’s life situation. In other words, Paul focused more on Christian life and witness than on physical freedom.

Even slaves can do their work as an act of worship (Ephesians 6:5–8; Colossians 3:22–24; compare 1 Timothy 6:1–2). When Paul speaks to Christian slaves, he encourages them to see their situation as a calling where they can serve Christ. Christ is their true master, and in him, they are truly free (1 Corinthians 7:20–24).

Every Christian, whether slave or free, has been freed from the worst kind of slavery, slavery to sin. They can now experience true freedom by living as a servant of God and righteousness (Romans 6:6–22). For Paul, this is the only kind of slavery and freedom that truly matters.

Passages for Further Study

Romans 6:6–22; 1 Corinthians 7:20–24; 9:19; Ephesians 6:5–8; Colossians 3:22–24; 1 Timothy 6:1–2; Philemon 1:8–21

Social Chaos in Judges

The book of Judges emphasizes divine rescue through heroes but also shows the problems of their current situation. During this time, personal commitment to God decreased while social problems increased. This is especially true in chapter 5 (for example, 5:6–8).

Three main issues stand out:

1. The tribes struggled to work together, even against a common enemy (see, for example, the stories of Gideon and Jephthah; chapters 8, 12). The conflicts within each tribe and between different tribes show disobedience to the covenant.
2. The book shows the collapse of civil society. Abimelech kills Gideon’s sons, Jephthah seems to sacrifice his daughter, and Samson seeks revenge against the Philistines. These acts emphasize the moral corruption and lack of social politeness during this time.
3. Abandoning the Jewish faith was common in those days. The Israelites often did “evil in the sight of the LORD,” which linked to idol worship (Judges 2:11–13; 3:7; 10:6). The altar to Baal and the Asherah pole in Gideon’s town of Ophrah show an obvious abandoning of the Lord (6:25–30). This is similar to the worship of the golden ephod made by Gideon and the return to worshipping Baal after Gideon’s death (8:27, 33–35). Samson’s marriage to a Philistine woman also went against the covenant commands (see Deuteronomy 7:1–4).

Social chaos peaks in the final chapters (Judges 17–21). The story of Micah, the Levite, and the Danites mixes religious problems with lawless raids, theft, and violence (chapters 17–18). The intense final section tells of a tragic civil war and the complete loss of social politeness (chapters 19–21).

Marital problems, lack of hospitality, rape, and murder almost wiped out the Benjamites (chapters Judges 19 and 20). They survived only because the Israelites destroyed a historic city, Jabesh-gilead. Then a fake ceremony allowed the Benjamites to take young virgins as wives (21:6–23). It is no surprise that the book ends with, “In those days there was no king in Israel; everyone did what was right in his own eyes” (21:25).

Passages for Further Study

Judges 5:6–8; 6:25–27; 8:1–35; 12:1–15; 17:1–21:25; Psalms 11:2–7; Proverbs 28:2–3; Jeremiah 5:7–9; 12:1–17; Micah 3:9–12; 7:2–7; Romans 1:21–32; Galatians 5:19–23

Social Justice

In the Old Testament, prophets often challenged evil in society and called for social justice (fair treatment of all people, especially the poor and vulnerable). An early example is the prophet Elijah’s response to Naboth’s murder and his rebuke of King Ahab (1 Kings 21:16–24, 800s BC). The social focus of the prophetic message grew stronger among the prophets of the 700s BC. The prophets Hosea and Amos emphasized this social focus in Israel, and the prophets Micah and Isaiah in Judah. The prophet Amos was the most vocal about social justice.

Israel’s bad treatment of the powerless shocked the prophet Amos (Amos 2:6–8; 3:10). Unlike nearby nations, Israel had a special relationship with God, but they abandoned him (2:9–12; 3:1–2). The people of Israel refused to worship God properly and oppressed the powerless, so God would judge them without mercy (4:12). God wants his people “to let justice roll on like a river” (Amos 5:24). Those who resist it will be swept away.

The New Testament emphasized the importance of social justice. Jesus linked true worship with practicing social justice. He warned about judgment for those who do not show their faith through loving actions (see Matthew 25:31–46). Understanding must link to action, proving one’s faith (see Luke 10:25–37; John 13:35). The followers of Jesus understood that social justice was essential in early Christian communities (see Acts 2:44–45; Galatians 2:9–10; 1 Timothy 5:3–16; James 1:27–2:26; 1 John 3:17–19).

Scripture shows God’s compassion for those who suffer. As followers of Jesus, we must help those in need. Like the prophets, we must stand against injustice wherever we find it.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 23:1–12; Leviticus 19:9–18; Deuteronomy 10:17–20; 16:18–20; 24:10–22; 1 Kings 21:1–24; 2 Chronicles 19:4–11; Psalms 94:20–23; 146:3–9; Proverbs 22:8–9; 31:8–9; Ecclesiastes 5:8–9; Isaiah 1:17; 5:7; 9:6–7; 10:1–2; 42:1–4; 58:4–12; Amos 2:6–8; 5:7–17, 23–24; Matthew 12:15–21; 23:23; Luke 10:25–37; Hebrews 1:8–9

Solomon’s Wisdom

When God gave King Solomon the chance to ask for anything, Solomon chose wisdom. He wanted to govern God’s people well and know right from wrong (1 Kings 3:9). Because of this unselfish choice, God granted him the wisdom he wanted and the rewards of using it properly (3:12, 13–14; 2 Chronicles 1:14–17).

Solomon’s actions quickly showed his wisdom. He solved a dispute over a child so wisely that it amazed the people (1 Kings 3:16–28). Later, the queen of Sheba visited to challenge him with difficult questions. She found his wisdom greater than she had heard (10:1–9).

Many things showed Solomon’s wisdom, including:

- how he organized and managed his government and officials (4:1–28);
- how he handled relationships with other nations and kings (5:1–9);
- the structures he built, especially the temple and his palace (5:10–7:51); and
- his business dealings and trade with other nations (9:26–28; 10:14–29).

Solomon gained vast knowledge (4:29–33). He wrote proverbs (much of the book of Proverbs) as well as songs (Psalms 72; 127). He also wrote love poetry (see the Song of Songs) and philosophical works (see Ecclesiastes). He used his wisdom to build the temple (2 Chronicles 2:12). This was like Bezalel who had been given wisdom to build the tabernacle (Exodus 31:1–3).

Jesus emphasized Solomon’s great wisdom and told his listeners that, “One greater than Solomon is here” (Matthew 12:42). Jesus is the true wisdom of God, where one can find ultimate wisdom (1 Corinthians 1:24). A wise life is centered in Jesus and in Scripture (1 Corinthians 1:18–25; Colossians 3:16; 2 Peter 3:18; 2 Timothy 3:14–17).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 31:1–6; 1 Kings 3:5–14; 3:16–28; 4:29–34; 5:2–7; 10:1–13; 2 Chronicles 1:7–12; Psalms 72:1–20; 111:10; 127:1–5; Ecclesiastes 12:9–14; Isaiah 11:1–5; Jeremiah 9:23–24; Matthew 12:42; James 1:5

The Son of God

Jesus' healings, exorcisms (casting out demons), raising the dead, and teachings resulted in wonder, awe, amazement, and fear (for example, Mark 1:22, 27; 4:41; 5:15, 20, 33; 7:37; 9:15; 10:24, 26, 32; 12:17; 15:5). This amazement emphasizes the miraculous nature of Jesus' ministry. The Gospel writers wanted readers to ask, "What kind of man is this? Even the winds and the sea obey Him!" (Matthew 8:27; Mark 4:41; Luke 8:25). Mark answers this at the start of his Gospel: Jesus is the "Christ, the Son of God" (Mark 1:1).

In the Old Testament, the title "Son of God" refers to the people of Israel (Exodus 4:22; Deuteronomy 32:5–6, 18–19; Psalm 82:6; Jeremiah 3:19; 31:9, 20; Hosea 11:1; Malachi 2:10). It can refer to angels (Genesis 6:2; Job 1:6; 2:1; 38:7; Psalm 29:1). It also has a special meaning for Israel's king, as they regarded the anointed king as God's "son" (2 Samuel 7:14; 1 Chronicles 22:10; 28:6; Psalms 2:7; 89:26–27).

The title also appears in Jewish writings between the Old and New Testaments (including the Apocrypha and the Dead Sea Scrolls). It possibly refers to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one). Jews in the first century likely considered the coming Messiah as a "Son of God."

God confirmed Jesus as "the Son of God" at his baptism (Mark 1:11; Matt 3:17; Luke 3:22). Demons also recognized him during his ministry (Matthew 8:29; Mark 1:24; 1:34; 3:11; 5:7; Luke 4:34; 8:28). Later, the disciples acknowledged Jesus as the Christ (Matthew 16:16; Mark 8:29; Luke 9:20). Jesus then began teaching them about his coming death (Matthew 16:21; Mark 8:31; Luke 9:22).

At the transfiguration, Jesus' appearance changed to reveal his glory as God's Son, and God confirmed what the disciples had said about Jesus (Matthew 17:5; Mark 9:7; Luke 9:35). As Jesus neared his death, he affirmed his identity as God's Son through his teachings and during his trial (Mark 12:1–12; 13:32; Mark 14:61–62).

At Jesus' death on the cross, something powerful happened. A Roman soldier (called a centurion) who watched Jesus die was the first person in the story to acknowledge Jesus as "the Son of God" (Mark 15:39). Earlier in the Gospels, people had seen Jesus was God's Son when he drove out evil spirits, and God himself had announced Jesus as his Son. But it was

Jesus' willing death on the cross, and the way he died, that showed most clearly that he was truly God's Son (Mark 15:33–39).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 4:22; Deuteronomy 32:5–6; 2 Samuel 7:14; 1 Chronicles 22:10; 28:6; Psalms 2:7; 89:26–27; Jeremiah 3:19; 31:9, 20; Matthew 26:63–68; Mark 1:1, 11, 24; 4:35–41; 8:31; 9:7; 12:1–12; 14:61–62; 15:32–39; Luke 1:32–35; 4:41; John 1:18; 3:16–17, 35–36; 5:19–26; 17:5, 24; 20:31; Acts 13:33; Romans 1:4; 5:10; 8:3, 32; 2 Corinthians 1:19; Galatians 2:20; 4:4–5; Ephesians 4:13; 1 Thessalonians 1:10; Hebrews 1:2–14; 3:6; 5:5; 1 John 1:3; 2:22; 3:23; 4:9–10, 14; 5:20; 2 John 1:3, 9; Revelation 2:18

The Son of Man

"Son of Man" was Jesus' favorite way to refer to himself. The phrase is unusual in both Greek and English. It translates the Hebrew phrase *ben 'adam*, which means "human being" or "person" (see, for example, Ezekiel 2:1–8). Jesus liked this name because it did not cause debates like the titles "Christ" or "Messiah."

The Gospels use the expression in three ways:

1. The background to Jesus' use of the title comes from Daniel 7:13–14. In this passage, a messianic figure "like a son of man" (meaning "like a human") arrives with the clouds of heaven and receives great glory and power. Jesus saw himself as the one who would return to earth in the clouds of heaven (see Mark 8:38; 13:26; 14:62). Sometimes, Jesus used "Son of Man" to describe his role as judge, deliverer, savior, and the one who rights wrongs (Matthew 10:23; 13:41; 16:27; 19:28; 24:27, 30, 37, 44; 25:31; 26:64).
2. Jesus often called himself the "Son of Man" to show he was a suffering redeemer (Matthew 12:40; 17:9, 12, 22; 20:18, 28; 26:2, 24, 45). This idea comes from Isaiah 52:13–53:12.
3. Sometimes, Jesus used "Son of Man" to describe himself as a representative of humans (Matthew 8:20; 11:19; 12:8, 32; 13:37). The book of Ezekiel uses "son of man" in a similar way (again see, Ezekiel 2:1–8).

Jesus did not use "Son of Man" to separate his humanity from his divinity as "Son of God" sometimes does. By using this title, Jesus defined himself as the Messiah or Christ (God's chosen one) on his own terms. He used "Son of Man" to describe his complete identity and implied that those who watched and listened should recognize who he is.

Passages for Further Study

Ezekiel 2:1-8; 3:1, 4, 10, 17, 25; 4:1; Daniel 7:13-14; 8:17; Matthew 8:18-22; 9:6; 10:23; 11:19; 12:8, 32, 40; 13:37, 41; 16:13, 27-28; 17:9, 12, 22; 19:28; 20:18, 28; 24:27, 30, 37-39, 44; 25:31; 26:2, 24, 45, 64; Mark 2:10; John 1:51; 3:13-14; 5:27; 6:27, 53, 62; 8:28; 9:35; 12:23, 34; 13:31; Acts 7:56; Hebrews 2:6; Revelation 1:13; 14:14

The Sovereignty of God

People often think they can control everything that happens in their lives through their own choices and actions. But the Bible teaches us something different. It shows us that God has the highest power and authority over all things (see, for example, Deuteronomy 4:39; Psalms 135:5-7; Isaiah 46:8-11; Jude 1:24-25). While our choices and actions have real consequences, God's will (what God wants and plans) is much more important (see James 4:13-16).

God guides and controls everything that happens. We call this the sovereignty of God. God rules over the lives of all people (Psalm 135:5-12). God also controls the entire universe and everything that happens in the world's history (Isaiah 40:15-17; Acts 17:24; Colossians 1:15-20). God directs everything to his planned outcomes (Isaiah 46:10; Daniel 7:27-28; Matthew 24:14-31; Revelation 1:7-8).

In 2 Kings, God shows his power over nations. He chose and removed the kings of Israel and Judah based on His plans and their obedience. He allowed attacks on his people as punishment for their sins (2 Kings 8:18-22). God was in control when the Assyrians attacked Samaria and defeated the northern kingdom (17:1-6, 18, 20). King Hezekiah succeeded in Judah because of the Lord's blessings (18:5-7). God's influence is obvious in the complex international events during the rules of Judah's last kings, as he promised (23:26-27).

God shows his power by answering the prayers and requests of his people. When the Elisha prayed, God answered his faithful prophet. Through Elisha, God allowed the woman from Shunem to have a son and later brought that son back to life (2 Kings 4:17, 32-35). The Lord kindly answered King Jehoahaz's prayers and sent a rescuer for troubled Israel (13:4-5). He honored King Hezekiah's prayers for Jerusalem and for his own life (19:1-7; 20:1-6).

Paul shows that God decides the path of salvation. Paul often explains the surprising events in salvation history by referring to God's words and actions. Human choices alone cannot explain the situation. God has said, "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy" (Romans 9:15). Theologians will keep debating God's role and human choice in salvation, but God's control is evident.

Because God is sovereign, his people should try to live in harmony with his will (Romans 12:1-2). They should use the strength he provides (see 1 Corinthians 1:8-9). We can follow Christ's example in his prayer, "Yet not as I will, but as You will" (Matthew 26:39). Today, many people ignore God's influence in human affairs. Yet, God's decisions guide the world and the lives of those who trust him.

When we live for God's glory, everything that happens is ultimately for our good (Isaiah 42:8; Habakkuk 2:14; Jude 1:24-25; Psalm 84:11; Ephesians 3:16-19; Colossians 1:27; 2 Thessalonians 1:11-12). We can confidently say that "God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose" (Romans 8:28).

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 8:22; 9:29; Deuteronomy 4:39; 32:8, 39; Joshua 2:11; 1 Samuel 2:6-8; 2 Kings 13:4-5; 17:1-6, 18-20; 18:5-7; 19:5-7; 20:4-6; Psalms 24:1-2; 84:11; 135:5-12; Isaiah 40:15-17; 45:7; 46:10; Jeremiah 27:5-7; Daniel 7:27-28; Habakkuk 2:14; John 19:11; Acts 17:24-26; Romans 8:28; 9:5-24; 1 Corinthians 1:8-9; Colossians 1:15-20; 2 Thessalonians 1:11-12; Jude 1:24-25; Revelation 1:7-8

Speaking

Some people think words do not cause harm. Scripture offers a different perspective. Words hold the power of "life and death" (Proverbs 18:21).

Proverbs lists many things we say that cause harm:

- lies (Proverbs 14:5, 25)
- arguments (Proverbs 26:17)
- insults or curses (Proverbs 20:20)
- speaking falsely about someone to damage their reputation (Proverbs 10:18)
- spreading private information about others or unverified stories passed from person to person (Proverbs 11:13; 18:8)
- excessive or insincere praise given to manipulate someone (Proverbs 7:21-22)
- speaking too proudly about oneself (Proverbs 26:23; 27:2)

The book of Proverbs often emphasizes that foolish people say foolish things. "The woman named Folly" symbolizes these people (9:13-18). She lies and deceives to harm her listeners. Words show the heart's condition (16:23; 18:4).

Someone might hide an evil heart with pleasant words (26:23). But true character will eventually appear (26:24-26). Foolish words harm others and eventually

hurt the speaker. The tongue is full of wickedness that can ruin your life (James 3:6).

In contrast, wise people speak words that give life, as shown by wisdom (Proverbs 8:7-9; 10:11). Wise people use their words carefully and are usually gentle (17:27-28; 15:4; 16:24). Yet, a wise person also knows the right time to speak (15:23; 25:11). This person understands that sometimes even harsh criticism is necessary (see 27:5). The book of Proverbs wisely reminds readers to pay attention not only to what they say but also to how and when they say it.

Passages for Further Study

Proverbs 7:21-22; 8:7-9; 9:13-18; 10:11, 18; 11:13; 14:5, 25; 15:4, 23; 16:23-24; 17:28; 18:4, 21; 20:20; 25:11; 26:17, 23-26; 27:2, 5; Matthew 12:33-37; James 3:1-12

Spirit Empowerment

Throughout the Bible, when needed, God gives special abilities to those committed to serving him. The story of Moses and the seventy elders is an early example. It shows that God has acted in special ways among his people throughout history. When Moses had no more patience for rebellious Israel, God instructed him to choose seventy men to assist him (Numbers 11:1-15, 16-17; see also Exodus 18:14-26). Then, God shared the Holy Spirit that Moses had with these men, empowering them for service (Numbers 11:24-25).

God's Spirit-empowered Joshua to succeed Moses (Numbers 27:18; see also Deuteronomy 34:9). During the time of the judges, the Spirit of God helped Israel's leaders. This included:

- Othniel (Judges 3:10);
- Gideon (Judges 6:34);
- Jephthah (Judges 11:29); and
- Samson (Judges 13:25; 14:6, 19; 15:14).

King David drew strength from God's presence. His understanding of God's actions in history and his life made him a great leader (for example, 1 Samuel 16:13; 17:45; 18:12, 28). The prophets knew their special work was possible because of the Spirit's presence and power (for example, Isaiah 61:1; Ezekiel 11:5; Zechariah 4:6).

God's Spirit anointed Jesus and empowered for a special mission (see Matthew 12:18; Luke 4:1, 14, 18; John 3:34; Acts 10:38). He spoke about the Spirit's important role in the church (Acts 1:8). The Spirit's arrival allowed the gathered Christians to speak with power on the day of Pentecost (Acts 2:4-5, 16-18; compare Joel 2:28-29).

After Pentecost, the Spirit gave the church courage and strength (Acts 4:31; 19:6; 20:28; 1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Galatians 3:2-5). The Holy Spirit still remains with God's people today. The Spirit acts as needed to renew and strengthen God's people. He continues to prepare them for the tasks God calls them to do.

Passages for Further Study

Numbers 11:16-30; 24:1-9; 27:18-23; Deuteronomy 34:10-12; Judges 3:9-10; 6:34; 11:29; 14:5-6, 19; 15:14; 1 Samuel 16:13; Psalms 23; 46:1; 94:16-19; 116:1-9; 121:1-8; 143:10-12; Isaiah 61:1; Ezekiel 11:5; Joel 2:28-29; Zechariah 4:6; Matthew 12:18; Luke 4:1, 14, 18; John 3:34; Acts 1:8; 2:4, 16-18; 4:31; 10:38; 19:6; 20:28; 1 Corinthians 12:1-31; Galatians 3:2-5

The Spirit of the Law

When King Hezekiah wanted to celebrate Passover, he had a problem. Passover is a feast marking Israel's freedom from slavery in Egypt and is the first feast of Israel's religious year (Exodus 12:1-2). Hezekiah intended to restore Israel's worship of the Lord. Yet, the time between starting his renewal efforts and the first month of the year was too short. The priests did not have enough time to prepare and gather the people (2 Chronicles 30:2-3). As a result, he could not celebrate Passover at the usual time.

Hezekiah held the Passover a month late (2 Chronicles 30:15). He believed celebrating was more important than the timing. By delaying, he gave people time to gather at the temple in Jerusalem. This brought harmony between Judah and the northern kingdom and unified the celebration.

Following precise regulations was less important than guaranteeing everyone could celebrate Passover. When the feast began, many people had not properly purified themselves. So they could not slaughter their own sacrifices as the law required.

Hezekiah decided participation in Passover was more important than strict obedience to regulations. He prayed for the pilgrims who could not prepare properly. Although they could not make sacrifices without being pure, they could still participate in Passover. Having the right attitude and seeking the Lord in prayer led to God's gracious acceptance (2 Chronicles 30:18-20; see also 1 Corinthians 11:27-34).

Religious leaders often criticized Jesus for not following all aspects of the law. They especially were concerned about the Sabbath and purity. Jesus taught that showing love to others was more important than following every detail of the law. He also criticized religious leaders for focusing too much on the details of

the law instead of the principles behind them. While strict obedience to the law was key to Jewish identity, the spirit of the law allowed some flexibility in certain situations.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 12:1–30; 2 Kings 5:17–19; 2 Chronicles 30:1–27; Matthew 15:21–28; John 8:1–11; Romans 3:23–28; 1 Corinthians 11:27–34; Hebrews 9:13–15; James 5:16

The Spirit's Presence

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of the Lord came to people or groups when God gave them a task or chose them for a role. The Spirit empowered judges like Othniel, Gideon, and Jephthah for their duties (Judges 3:10; 6:34; 11:29). Saul and David received the Spirit of God when anointed as kings (1 Samuel 10:1, 9–10; 16:13).

The Spirit left when the task ended or the person lost their role. When Samuel anointed David as the next king, the Spirit left Saul (16:13, 14). This was because he was disobedient and God rejected him as king (13:7–14; 15:10–29; compare 28:15; Judges 16:20). After David sinned with Bathsheba, he prayed to avoid the same judgment, “take not Your Holy Spirit from me” (Psalm 51:11).

In the New Testament, God's Holy Spirit is given to everyone who trusts in Jesus for salvation, not just to those in specific roles (see Acts 2:14–21; 1 Corinthians 12:1–13; Ephesians 1:13–14). The Spirit helps God's servants do the work they are called to do (see 1 Corinthians 12:7–10). The Old Testament story of the Spirit leaving Saul shows why the New Testament warns against sinning against the Spirit and causing him sorrow (see Mark 3:28–29; Ephesians 4:30; Hebrews 6:1–8).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 41:37–40; Exodus 31:1–6; Judges 3:9–11; Judges 6:34; Judges 11:29; Judges 14:5–6; Judges 16:20–21; 1 Samuel 10:1–10; 1 Samuel 11:6–7; 1 Samuel 16:13–23; 1 Samuel 19:19–23; 2 Chronicles 20:13–19; 2 Chronicles 24:20–22; Psalm 51:11–12; Isaiah 11:1–5; Jeremiah 31:33–34; Joel 2:28–29; Mark 3:28–29; Acts 2:1–21; Acts 4:31; Ephesians 1:13–14; Ephesians 4:30; Hebrews 6:4–8

Spiritual Maturity

When someone trusts in Jesus Christ for salvation, it marks the beginning of a journey that will continue the rest of their life. They do not stay the same. They transform and grow to be more like Jesus. This process is called “sanctification.” Like newborn babies need milk to grow before they can eat solid food, new Chris-

tians need “pure spiritual milk” to fully experience salvation (1 Peter 2:2–3). Eventually, they will be ready for the “solid food” of deeper teachings (Hebrews 5:11–14).

Spiritual maturity involves the ability to understand spiritual wisdom (1 Corinthians 2:6). The apostle Paul commands Christians to think maturely (1 Corinthians 14:20). The body of Christ matures as Christians become spiritually equipped and learn about the Son of God (Ephesians 4:11–16). This leads to a united faith community where love and truth strengthen the body of Christ.

The audience of Hebrews was spiritually immature. The author wanted to provide them with substantial spiritual teachings. But they behaved like spiritual infants who needed basic nourishment instead of deeper lessons (Hebrews 5:12). They had not been attentive to God's teachings. They had been Christians long enough to teach others, but their growing insensitivity made them spiritually dull (5:11–12; compare 1 Corinthians 3:1–3).

They lacked the maturity to understand the basic difference between right and wrong (Hebrews 5:14). Therefore, the author challenged them to grow into maturity. This was so he could share deeper truths of the faith, instead of repeatedly covering the basics (6:1–3).

Spiritual maturity does not happen automatically over time. It comes from actively listening to the word of God and living it out with a community of Christians.

Passages for Further Study

1 Corinthians 2:6; 3:1–3; 14:20; 2 Corinthians 13:9–11; Ephesians 4:11–16; Colossians 4:12; Hebrews 5:11–14; 6:1–3; 10:14; 12:1–2; 1 Peter 2:1–3

Spiritual Renewal in the Later Prophets

The prophet Haggai commanded his audience to think about how failing to pay attention to their relationship with God affected their current situation (Haggai 1:5–7; 2:15–18). God sent natural disasters as a warning to encourage repentance (2:17). Haggai understood that spiritual renewal needed to happen at the same time as rebuilding the temple (1:12).

The theme of spiritual renewal connects the prophets Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. They all came after the exile to Babylon. God returned his people to their land, as promised by earlier prophets. Yet, the people needed to focus on their spiritual condition to avoid more problems. The risk of disobeying God during this

time shows the need for the Lord's "servant" to come (see Haggai 2:23).

This servant first referred to Zerubbabel but later became regarded as the Messiah (God's chosen one). A righteous shepherd-king was coming (Zechariah 9:9; see also Malachi 3:1). God's presence would return in an obvious way. God would restore creation. The worship of the Lord would become universal.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 30:2-4; Psalm 22:27; Isaiah 11:9-12:6; 44:22, 26-28; 61:6-7; Jeremiah 24:4-7; Amos 4:6-12; Haggai 1:7-15; Zechariah 9:9; 14:9; Malachi 3:1

The Stone the Builders Rejected

Jesus continually offended the Jewish leaders and their followers. Although he was from the family line of King David, they questioned his mother's reputation (Matthew 1:18-25). Jesus came from Nazareth (Matthew 2:23). This place did not have a good reputation either (Matthew 13:53-58). He mainly worked in Galilee, far from the center of Jewish authority (Matthew 4:12-16). His closest friend was John, who became known for baptizing people and boldly speaking against political leaders as a prophet (Matthew 11:2-19; 14:3-12).

Jesus often gave indirect answers (Matthew 13:10-15; 17:24-27; 19:3-12; 21:23-27). He refused to show miraculous signs to prove his claims (12:38-42; 16:1-4). He spent time with people whom society rejected (9:9-13; 11:16-19). He challenged Jewish customs (5:17-20; 9:14-17; 12:1-14; 15:1-20; 21:12-13). He avoided public recognition (8:4; 12:15-21).

He shared his insights with unexpected people (Matthew 11:25-27; 13:16-17; 16:13-20). He spoke about the humiliating death he would suffer (16:21; 17:22-23; 20:18-19; 26:2). Jesus did not seek attention or make his role obvious. Instead, he chose humility, privacy, and sharing revelations that people could only understand through faith.

In the end, Jesus was proven right. He won arguments (Luke 20:20-40). He removed demons who had control of people (Matthew 8:28-34). He healed people in amazing ways (Matthew 9:1-8). He resurrected people from the dead (Matthew 9:18-26). Finally, he rose from the dead (Matthew 28:1-10). His ministry caused division but was effective in beginning God's kingdom on earth (Matthew 11:2-6).

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 3:8; 8:14-15; 28:12-13; 59:9-10; Jeremiah 13:16; 20:11; 31:7-9; 50:31-32; Hosea 4:4-6; 5:5; 14:9; Malachi

2:7-9; Matthew 11:5-6; 13:54-58; 17:27; 21:42-46; Mark 6:3; Luke 20:17-19; John 6:60-69; Romans 9:30-33; 11:7-12; 14:12-13, 20-21; 1 Corinthians 1:21-23; 8:9-13; 10:31-11:1; 2 Corinthians 6:3; Galatians 5:11; 1 Peter 2:5-8; 1 John 2:10

Suffering in Following God

Sometimes, people urge others to accept Jesus Christ because they promise that he will solve their problems. Yet, Jesus did not promise to solve all problems. He often warned people to think about the cost of following him (see, for example, Luke 14:28). He also emphasized the difficulties that would come from choosing to follow him (see, for example, Mark 8:34).

Exodus 5 gives us an example of how following God can sometimes lead to more challenges at first. In the beginning, Pharaoh made the Hebrew people slaves because he was afraid they were becoming too numerous and might cause problems for Egypt (1:8-22). In chapter 5, the situation changes. Moses and Aaron had given the people hope by telling them that God would rescue them (4:29-31). When Moses and Aaron first met with Pharaoh, they told him that God was the true ruler over all (5:1-3). As expected, Pharaoh saw this as a challenge to his power as king, and he responded by making life even harder for the Israelites (5:4-21).

When God's kingdom opposes God's enemies, conflict and suffering often occur for God's people. This should not surprise us. When someone becomes a Christian, they leave behind a life controlled by evil and darkness. They begin a new life guided by God's goodness and light (Colossians 1:11-14). Those ruling the kingdom of darkness will not let us leave without a fight. We must stand firm in our faith, knowing that God will secure the final victory for us (Exodus 6:1-8; see also Matthew 5:11-12; John 16:33; Romans 16:20; Ephesians 6:10-18).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 39:6-20; Exodus 5:1-23; 18:8; 1 Kings 18:3-4; 19:1-10; Psalms 6:6-7; 22:11-18; Matthew 5:11-12; Mark 8:34; John 15:20; 16:33; Romans 16:20; 2 Corinthians 11:23-29; Ephesians 6:10-18; 2 Timothy 3:12; Hebrews 10:32-36; 1 Peter 1:6-7; 3:9-17; 4:12-19

The Suffering Prophet

In the Gospels, Jesus has many titles, such as Messiah (or Christ), Son of David, Son of Man, Son of God, and Lord. In Luke, an important title is "Prophet." Jesus is the prophet Moses predicted in Deuteronomy 18:15.

As a prophet, Jesus preached God's word and performed miracles like the great prophets of the Old

Testament. When Jesus raised a widow's son, the people exclaimed, "A great prophet has appeared among us!" (Luke 7:16). The disciples told Jesus that people were calling him a prophet (Matthew 16:13-14). The disciples on the road to Emmaus described him as "a prophet, powerful in speech and action before God and all the people" (Luke 24:19).

Like other prophets, Jesus suffered for his message (see 1 Kings 19:1-18; Jeremiah 11:18-19; 18:18; 20:1-2, 7-18; 26:7-11, 20-23; 38:1-6). People connected Jesus' role as a prophet to his miracles and teaching. But Jesus linked it mainly to his suffering. In Nazareth, he stated that "no prophet is accepted in his hometown" (Luke 4:24). He later accused Israel's leaders of killing their prophets (11:47-51). As he traveled to Jerusalem, he said, "it is not admissible for a prophet to perish outside of Jerusalem" (13:33).

In the Old Testament, when Israel ignored God's prophets, divine judgment came. Similarly, God's people would encounter judgment if they did not listen to Jesus (see Acts 3:22-23).

The revelation that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one) shows he is the savior for all people. His role as a prophet shows his message is from God. His words are truly God's words, which people must hear and follow.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 18:15; Matthew 5:12; 23:34-37; Luke 4:22-24; 6:23, 26; 7:16; 11:47-52; 13:33-34; 24:17-21; Acts 3:22-23; 7:37, 52

The Superiority of the Son

The book of Hebrews shows why Jesus, the Son of God, is greater than all others in who he is (his nature) and what he does (his ministry).

Superior in Nature

The Son's superior nature is mainly discussed in Hebrews 1:1-3:6. In the book's introduction (1:1-4), the Son is shown as the creator, supporter, and heir of the universe (1:2-3). He is "the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of His nature" (1:3). He is honored, having cleansed sins and has a status "far superior to the angels" (1:3-4).

Superior to Angels

In Hebrews 1:5-14 and 2:5-18, the Son is shown to be greater than the angels. He has a special relationship with the Father (1:5). He is the ruler, creator, and he who changes the created world (1:8-12). The angels have a lower status than him, and they worship him (1:6-7). God the Father raises him to the highest posi-

tion of honor at his right hand (1:13; Psalm 110:1). He has authority over everything (Hebrews 2:5-8).

Superior to Moses

In Hebrews 3:1-6, the author uses the respect his audience has for Moses to argue for even greater respect for the Son. Like Moses, the Son was faithful in serving God's people. Yet, the Son deserves more glory and praise than Moses because he has the same nature as God the Father. The Son is the ultimate builder of God's house (3:3-4). The Son is ultimately in charge of God's people (3:5-6).

Superior Ministry

Superior Priest

The sections highlighting the Son's superior ministry are mainly in Hebrews 7:1-10:18. Through his superior role as high priest, Jesus has introduced a "better hope" (7:19). "A better covenant" guarantees this hope (7:22). "Better promises" ground this hope (8:6). This allows him to perform a ministry "more excellent" than that of the old covenant priests (8:6). The old covenant was the agreement God made with the Israelites through Moses.

Superior Sacrifice

Jesus' ministry under the new covenant is a better system because of his "better sacrifices" (9:10, 23; see also 12:24). The new covenant is the new agreement God made through Jesus. Jesus' ministry leads new-covenant believers in God to expect "a better and permanent possession" (10:34). It is a "better country, a heavenly one" (11:16). They will "gain a better resurrection" (11:35). For believers in Jesus under the new covenant, God has "planned something better" that old-covenant believers could only anticipate (11:40).

Passages for Further Study

Psalm 110:1; Hebrews 1:1-14; 3:1-6; 7:1-10:18; 10:34; 11:16, 35, 40

Symbolic Numbers

Numbers in Scripture have often led people to strange conclusions. Understanding ancient number symbolism can help us interpret the Scriptures better. Yet, this symbolism is not precise. We must be careful when using numbers in interpretation to avoid making unrealistic predictions about the future.

In the Bible, numbers often have special meanings:

- The number one can refer to God's unity (Deuteronomy 6:4; Galatians 3:20; James 2:19).

- Two is the minimum number of people needed to provide a valid witness in court (Deuteronomy 17:6; Revelation 11:3).
- Three can imply divine presence (Genesis 18:1-2; 2 Corinthians 13:14; Revelation 1:4-5).
- Four can represent the known world. The book of Revelation indicates this with living creatures, horsemen, winds, and angels (Revelation 4:6-8; 6:1-8; 7:1). Genesis 2:10-14 indicates this with four rivers.
- Adding three and four to make seven represents perfection or divine fulfillment. This shows harmony between God and the world.
- Multiplying three by four gives twelve, the number linked to God's people (Genesis 35:22-26; Exodus 24:4; 28:21; Numbers 17:2; Joshua 4:3-8; 1 Kings 18:31; Matthew 10:1-4; 19:28; James 1:1; Revelation 12:1; 21:12-22:2).
- The number five and its multiples, like ten, represent human completeness. For example, there are five fingers per hand.
- Six has a negative meaning, suggesting imperfection. It is neither humanly complete (five) nor divinely complete (seven).
- Multiples of ten represent many (for example, forty). In contrast, three sixes or "666" suggest extreme evil (Revelation 13:18).
- One thousand is the basic large number. The number 12,000 represents a large group of God's people (Revelation 7:5-8). One hundred and forty-four thousand represents all of God's people (Revelation 7:4; 14:1). The Greek transliteration myriads best represents what some translations call "10,000." This is because it is really a huge number, rather than an exact count.

Ephesians 4:4-6; 2 Peter 3:8; Revelation 1:16; 2:10; 4:4; 6:1; 7:1, 4-8; 12:1, 3; 13:1; 17:3-14; 20:2-7; 21:12-21

Some numbers in the Bible have symbolic meanings. Yet, it is extremely doubtful to use them to guess when Christ will return or when the world will end. Only God knows these things (Mark 13:32). God did not intend for the symbolic numbers in Revelation to predict the future. Instead, they explain the importance of the visions.

Translating these numbers into modern sizes, distances, or quantities can sometimes lose their theological meaning. These symbolic numbers can show how a vision relates to the world or to God's people.

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:2-3; 4:15; 15:13; 41:53-54; Exodus 20:6; 25:31-37; 32:15; Leviticus 16:14; 23:16; 2 Samuel 24:13; 1 Kings 4:26; 17:21; 18:31, 43-44; Job 1:2; Psalm 90:4; Jeremiah 15:3; 49:36; Ezekiel 14:21; Daniel 4:16, 23-25; 7:3, 17, 24; Zechariah 4:2; 6:1; Matthew 10:1-5; 12:40; 18:21-22; Mark 6:7; Luke 15:8; Acts 6:3; 10:16; 1 Corinthians 8:6;